Shotgun (you would've carried me home)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/72759671.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/M, F/F, M/M

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Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

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by caramelaire

Summary

> “Give me a proper kiss tomorrow?”
>
> “That’s if you remember any of this.”
>
> They only ever make progress when they're drunk. The problem is they almost always barely remember. Or do they?
>
> —
> Bow's leaving for college and Glimmer's staying behind, but not after a farewell party turns into a drunken confession they'll pretend never happened.

Notes

> Inspired by the song Shotgun by Michele Lu.
>
> another songfic, cara? well yes, because this is the only way I write now!
>
> The first chapter's angsty, second is tooth-rotting sweet, and third is just a silly thing I wrote while pumped with sugar and caffeine.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: That night

Glimmer wasn't the drunk person here, but all the Sea Hawk talk was making her dizzy. She tuned out the ramblings of the mess in her passenger seat and zeroed in on the rearview mirror, easing out of the tight parking space.

Her hands were cold and just slightly unsteady on the wheel. It had everything to do with the fact that she had only gotten her driver's license last week, was terrible at parallel parking, and now had her drunk best friend's life in her hands. Definitely not because he couldn't shut up about his new boyfriend.

She took a deep breath as she concentrated.

"Hey. Seatbelt," she quipped toward the passenger side.

"Then he offered to drive me to campus next week, help me move my things… We're going to make a road trip out of it. You know, make the most of it before classes start—"

"Bow. Seatbelt." Glimmer's voice cut in, louder. He was slurring, dragging through his words, talking so loudly, so she had to be heard somehow. It wasn't like she was shouting at him.

"Huh—wha?"

She rolled her eyes, finally glancing his way. She could see the party they had just left still in full swing through the window. Adora, Catra, and Scorpia were huddled together on the balcony with the rest of her basketball team, everyone laughing too loud.

It was the farewell party for the senior athletes. She should've gone, should've joined them. But in light of her best friend's recent life updates, Glimmer just hadn't been up for pretending today. And yet, there she was anyway, roped into it by the end of the night.

She reached across the passenger seat, fingers fumbling with his seatbelt. He followed her movements curiously, or as best as any drunk person could.

His eyes met hers, breath brushing her cheek, that sharp tang of tequila clinging to him. Glimmer became suddenly, startlingly aware of just how close this position brought her to him.

She yanked his seatbelt, clicked it in, and dropped back into her seat in an instant. Crazy how she was suddenly so out of breath, as if she just ran a mile.

She blasted the AC to cool herself down, strapped in her own seatbelt, and finally managed to pull onto the road.

"Hey, Glimmerrrr," he slurred.

Her lips pressed thin. Him sitting shotgun was making her way too nervous.

"Yeah, Bow?"

"Thanks for picking me up…" he said, voice clearer than a second ago. Before she could respond, she felt a weight pressing on her arm and realized he had leaned his head against it.

Half of her wanted to let him nuzzle there. Half of her wanted to shove him off—for driving safety reasons, of course. Not that her snail's-pace driving could have been any more careful.

"Don't mention it," she muttered, eyes locked on the turn ahead.

"I didn't think I'd get soooo thrashed," Bow laughed. He shifted, his head landing on her lap. Goddamnit. Why was this road so dark? Where were the streetlights?

"Bow, stop distracting me! I'm driving!" The words snapped out. It felt so foreign, reprimanding him like this. He was supposed to be the careful one.

"Oops," he hiccupped. "Sorry, Glimmerrr." A beat of silence, then giggles. He was giggling now, burying his face in her shirt.

Her lips twitched, holding back the smile threatening to break through. He was annoying her with all the drunken love talk, but god, she was going to miss him so much when he left for college.

Her fingers tightened on the wheel.

Why did she have to be a year younger?

A sting pricked behind her eyes. She sucked in a slow, steady breath.

Nope, she had gone over this. Over and over. A whole year of dealing with these emotions and bracing herself for the upcoming school year.

She had even made a battle plan to survive senior year with as few breakdowns and meltdowns as possible. She had ugly cried and sobbed it all out at their graduation until she swore there was nothing left. A week out from the big move, she was supposed to be in the acceptance stage.

Right?

She muttered it under her breath, a reminder as much as an answer.

What she hadn't prepared for at all was that one last curveball Bow threw her way: a boyfriend. *That* broke open the dam and floodgates of change she had been dreading all year.

Still, she told herself she was over it. She had cried herself to sleep enough nights. She had accepted it.

"So, where's Sea Hawk?" It was a stupid, ridiculous name. She hated even saying it, and she couldn't have cared less how he had gotten the nickname.

The dragon boat captain Bow had been dating in the last few weeks.

Glimmer hadn't even really met the guy. Just a handful of passing greetings at parties, quick nods at school events. That was partly because she avoided seeing them together like the plague, and partly because Bow was always too busy.

Their moments together lately had been nothing but packing sessions, like she was just another thing he was putting in a box.

"With his buddiesss…" he slurred. "Since it's our last week with everyone… Buttttt it's a good thing we're attending the same college, you knoww? I don't have to worry about long-distance or something. What'd he say? He said it's our next ADVENTURE together," he laughed, loud in the small car.

Glimmer hummed noncommittally, because really, what was she supposed to say to all of that? Congratulations, you're starting your life without me—

"Oh!" Bow lurched upright, sudden enough that Glimmer almost jerked the wheel.

"Bow!"

"Sorryyy." His drunkenly sheepish grin met her scolding glare. "Heyyy, am I being insensitive? I'm sorry, I'm so drunk."

"No. I want—" she stumbled, then forced the words out. "I want to hear it. Besides…" She eased the car to a stop at a red light. "We never talk about him."

Bow slumped against the window and stared at the streetlights with a glazed over look.

"By the way… why don't we *ever* talk about him?" Glimmer asked, hesitant.

It had always been a weird, touchy subject for them—almost as if he were avoiding it just as much as she wanted to. Like Bow had carved his life into two separate worlds: Glimmer in one, his relationship in the other. The line between them neatly drawn, never overlapping.

When he first announced it, it had been through a rush of nervous rambles while Glimmer sat frozen to stone.

It blindsided her, to say the least. He had never said he'd been interested in anyone. Just, one day, he *was.* Rushed through the story of how they met, how he'd had a crush on the guy forever (curious, because Glimmer *never* heard of that).

Then, Bow quickly introduced the two of them at a school event, which was brief and awkward, like he couldn't wait to pull them apart again.

After that, his relationship played in the background of their friendship. Glimmer never asked, and Bow never offered. For a while, she could almost pretend it didn't exist.

Until they had both gotten accepted to the same college. Suddenly, it wasn't in the background anymore. It was the future. And Glimmer wasn't in it.

Sea Hawk would have Bow all to himself, while she stayed behind another year, and by the time she finally caught up, they'd already be so in love and inseparable she'd be irrelevant, and then they would get married, and that would be it.

Oh, shoot. She almost missed the green light.

"What do you mean?" Bow hiccupped. "I've been talking about him the whole night." She stole a glance at him. He was still slumped against the window.

"Guess you're right," she muttered. "Takes getting you drunk to finally open up to me about it, huh."

But he was already snoring lightly. Bad timing, because with that last quip, Glimmer had successfully worked herself up.

Everything was changing, and no matter how hard she had tried to prepare for it, who was she kidding? She was absolutely terrified, of being left behind, of being alone, of being pushed out of his life, of him moving on without her.

She had been desperate to milk these last few weeks, trying to spend every waking second with him, but even that she had been forced to share with someone he would be spending the whole next year with anyway.

She had even taken those stupid driving lessons just to be the one to help him move out. It was supposed to be their one last road trip together.

But of course—

Fuck. She'd finally done it. Worked herself up to tears. Glimmer gripped the steering wheel, not even noticing how hard she was pressing the pedal, how fast they were going.

"*Why* would you rather be with *him* than with *me*?" The frustrated words ripped out before she could stop them, and in the same instant, Bow's hand clamped around her arm.

"Glimmer—"

"Oh, shit!" She slammed the brake, and they lurched forward as the car screeched to a halt. Heavy silence enveloped the vehicle, broken only by the sound of the car engine and Glimmer's heart pounding against her ears.

"Oh fuck. I just ran a red light." And said something so, *so* stupid. *Fuck.*

Her heart hammered a million miles an hour. She shakily pulled the car to the curb under a streetlight. Her eyes flicked to the

mirror, checking for cops. Thank God the streets were dead at this hour.

His hand was still gripping her arm. She couldn't look at him, not after what she had just blurted out. She was beating herself up in her head because he was supposed to be asleep.

"Give me a sec," Glimmer muttered, still not meeting his eyes. "That scared the shit out of me."

He was quiet now, but his hand didn't let go.

"What did you just say?"

Chills ran down her spine. Years of intermittently denying or keeping this secret of hers, only for it to come out in the most careless way possible on a drunken night. And *she wasn't even the drunk one!*

"I—what… I thought you were sleeping."

"I wasn't… and you were going way too fast," Bow leaned unsteadily, trying to catch her eyes.

"I didn't say anything," cleared her throat. "You must be drunk-dreaming."

A beat of silence, him shifting in his seat as she tried her best to turn away from him.

"Except you did." His voice was heavy with meaning.

Pinching the bridge of her nose in frustration, she let out a groan. Who was she kidding? These emotions had been raging inside her the past few weeks. It was like a deadline pounding in her head, looming over every moment she had spent with Bow.

She was tired of fighting it. Maybe it wasn't so bad to put it—her—out of her misery. At least this time, there weren't any *maybes*

or *what-ifs* to torment her. This time she knew what the answer was. She was as good as rejected.

She exhaled, sharp and shaky. "You know what, fuck it. Everything's about to change anyway. This is just one more thing to add to the pile! We won't even see each other that often anymore, so it's kind of perfect, right? Any awkwardness this causes won't even matter once you're gone."

It sounded more like she was convincing herself than anything, and it probably was.

"What… What are you talking about?" Bow's hand tightened on her arm.

"Bow…" Her throat was tight. "I know you're already dating someone else. And I really, really shouldn't be doing this—not out of respect for your relationship. Least of all while you're drunk. And… it's too late for me anyway. I'm too late."

Her grip tightened on the wheel, knuckles white, eyes tightly shut, like she couldn't bear to watch herself steer their friendship into a dead end.

"I'm sorry for being selfish again,," she breathed. "But I think I finally need to say it. I just can't drag this torture out while you're miles away…"

Silence. A pause for her to catch her fucking breath.

"Glimmer?" He sounded so lost, concerned, and a bit out of it, to be honest. That gave her added confidence, knowing he wasn't all there.

Glimmer tried to swallow the words back in a moment of split-second hesitation. But they tumbled out anyway, breaking through, "I love you, Bow."

"I love—"

"No," she cut him off, shaking her head. "I'm *in love* with you. I've been in love with you for years. I'm your best friend and I know I shouldn't have let this happen, but…" she broke their gaze and leaned her head on the wheel, whispering, "How could I not fall for you? You're the best thing to ever happen to me."

The words hung in the car. Irrevocable. For a second, all she could hear was the engine humming.

His grip on her arm loosened, and for a long moment, he just breathed. Finally, one word slipped out. "...shit."

She exhaled a self-deprecating laugh. "Shit is right."

"No, I mean, Glimmer—listen, I—" Bow stuttered. "You're the best thing… God, Glimmer, you're my favorite person. You matter to me, more than—"

Before he could finish, he lurched forward suddenly, hands clamped over his mouth. "I need to—"

He fumbled for the door and retched onto the curb. Glimmer reached over to his side, rubbing his back, feeling guilty for unloading this on him now of all times, when he was drunk and hardly able to process what she was saying.

When he was done, Bow slumped back against his seat, breathing ragged.

Glimmer grabbed a bottle of water from the backseat, cranked it open, and offered it to him. He took a long drink.

"Sorry," he murmured after, wiping his chin and gripping the plastic in his hands until it crackled. "I—I didn't mean… that wasn't about what you said."

Glimmer let out a laugh, hated how it sounded like self-pity. "I know. Great timing, though. I really know how to pick my moments, huh?"

“I’m serious,” Bow insisted, eyes half-closed. He looked pale, wrecked. “You’re everything to me.”

Glimmer shook her head, with a small, sad smile that didn’t quite reach her eyes, as if she didn’t believe what he had just said. “Bow, you… you don’t have to say anything, really, or reciprocate. I already know you don’t. But I… I just wanted you to know.”

She took his hands briefly, gave them a small squeeze, but had to let go just as quickly. Before she held on for dear life.

“A fresh start, you know,” Glimmer laughed humorlessly. “For both of us.”

So she could finally let him go. It was the same mantra she had been drilling into herself for months, a flimsy cover for the monster in her chest that just wanted to scream. She almost had herself convinced.

With that finality, they sat there, the words having been said. She resumed driving as Bow recovered, and a few minutes later, they stopped in front of his house.

Glimmer killed the engine and sat for a long moment. She could feel his gaze on her as she opened her door and stepped out. The night air hit her like a splash of cool water against her flushed skin.

She crossed to his side and reached for the door.

“We’re here,” she said with a slight smile, subtly searching his eyes for a sign of where they stood after everything.

His eyes were glassy, too drunk to trust himself to respond properly, as if resigned to recording every detail in his head to mull over in the morning.

“Come here,” she helped him out, offering her hand to steady him. He took it, leaning into her warmth as if she were his anchor.

One arm around his shoulders, she felt the weight of him steadying her back.

They walked slowly toward the porch in silence. She carefully set him beside the door and used her spare keys to open it. They were drenched in shadows, only the streetlight and faint living room glow illuminating their faces.

She didn't even realize she was staring at him now, or that he was staring back. Frozen in time, heart in her throat, mind still in disbelief at what she had just done.

Then he leaned forward, too close, and the spell broke. Her stomach dropped. She turned away just as his lips landed, and they found home on her cheek instead. His warm breath ghosted just over her lips; she froze, wide-eyed, caught between wanting to pull away and wanting to stay.

The air between them hung tense.

Did he just…?

Instinctively, she placed a hand on his chest, pushing gently.

"Bow."

He was too close, all she was breathing was him, and it was making her think impossible, reckless thoughts. Her eyes stayed fixed on his, unwavering. He looked as lost as she felt.

His glassy eyes flickered to her lips. He moved closer again, slow, tentative, but she held her ground.

"What are you doing?" Her voice was soft, yet firm.

That seemed to snap him out of it. He blinked and took a staggered step back, a beat too slow. "Shit. I'm so, so sorry. Glimmer, I'm sorry. I don't know what came over—"

“You’re drunk.” Her chest rose and fell heavily. She felt every beat of her pulse, every inch of tension between them. It was like she was catching her breath just standing there.

Then his phone vibrated in her hand. Sea Hawk.

She gripped it, sneaking a glance at Bow as if they had been caught red-handed, and she answered.

“Hey, Sea Hawk,” she said, turning away from him. “It’s Glimmer.”

She shook her head. “Glim—Never mind. I drove Bow, yeah, he’s home safe now.” She nodded as he replied. “Uh-huh. He’ll talk to you in the morning… Uh, no, I won’t be sleeping over,” she paused. “Tha—that’s sweet, thanks. I’ll text when I get in.”

She hung up and turned to Bow without meeting his eyes.

“That was Sea Hawk. He’ll bring you breakfast in the morning. And I’m supposed to text him when I get home, but I don’t really have his number.”

Bow’s eyes stayed on her the whole time, silent.

“Yeah,” he trailed off, focused elsewhere. “Glimmer, let’s talk about —

She shook her head. “I don’t think we should. You’re too drunk, obviously,” she gave him a knowing yet apprehensive look. “And I’m tired. Let’s shelve this… maybe forever. I don’t even know if you’ll remember in the morning, honestly.”

“I’ll remember,” he tried to reach for her again, but she stepped back.

“You should go in,” she said softly.

“You should stay the night. Please. It’s too late,” he appealed to her, gesturing inside.

Glimmer shook her head, offering a tight smile. “Don’t worry. I’ll be careful.”

“Will you really be alright?”

“Yeah. I don’t have you to take care of me forever, right? I can handle myself. Worry about getting yourself up those stairs,” she laughed softly and began walking down the porch toward her car, not trusting herself to look back at him.

The wind whipped her hair, circling her like the way her thoughts were now beginning to catch up to reality. She pretended it was the reason her eyes began to blur.

“Is this goodbye?” he suddenly called to her, just as she was about to hop in. The words rang so loud in the stark naked silence of the early dawn.

Glimmer glanced back. He was leaning a hand on the porch, looking worried, as if he might chase after her any moment.

“No, silly,” she said with a grin, trying to sound as reassuring as possible. “I’ll see you tomorrow… Adora’s farewell party, right? Goodnight. I’ll text you in the morning.”

&

Glimmer drove off, and all that maturity finally wore out. The quiet hum of her car masked the storm inside her as she replayed it all in her head on a relentless loop.

By the time she got home, she was in tears. She dragged a suitcase from under her bed and tossed clothes inside without thought. Later, she climbed up to the roof where she and Bow used to watch the sunrise during sleepovers when they were kids.

The sky stretched out into beautiful pink hues bleeding into a gold horizon, but it brought her no comfort.

At breakfast, she would greet her parents like everything was normal, tell them she was taking the first plane out to their beach home, and stay there for the rest of the break.

It wasn't like her to run. She was usually the type to weather the storm or charge straight into a brick wall. But it was the season of change, and nothing was as it usually was.

She'd probably apologize to Bow for missing his farewell and moving out day. Except she never actually did end up sending that text.

Chapter 2: A year later

Bow hadn't taken a sip of anything, but stepping into the Seniors' farewell party was enough to make him feel a little tipsy. The air was heavy with alcohol, smoke, and sweat.

Teenagers hung about the balcony, all caught up in their own little worlds while the bass and lights raged through the house. Adora's grip dragged him forward, his eyes already darting past her, scouring the crowd for a flash of pink hair.

"BOW!" Adora was suddenly in his face, shouting over the music, trying to catch his attention. She gestured like a crazy person, pointing toward the next room, where the bodies were packed tighter, and mouthing something he could barely make out.

Catra's name, he thought, and maybe "I'll catch you later!" And then she was gone, swallowed by the crowd, off to find her girlfriend.

He waved her off, not that she waited for his reply. Anyway, he didn't plan to stay long.

They had only just made it back from the long drive from university, their car breaking down somewhere on the highway and making them miss his dads' homecoming dinner entirely. A small something to celebrate surviving his freshman year.

Now, well past midnight, Bow's luggage was still stranded in Adora's car. But here he was, first thing back in town, looking for *her*.

"You're Bow, the best friend, right?!"

He turned to see a girl with waves of deep blue hair and an expression that screamed boredom, arms crossed and an eyebrow raised.

He recognized her instantly. Mermista. He had seen her in Glimmer's feed, and Sea Hawk's too.

"Yeah!" At that, she grabbed him by the sleeve and tugged him down the hall, away from the noise, and into a side room where he could finally hear better.

"How'd you know me?" Bow asked, as the girl slowly scanned the room, searching for something.

"Tall. Crop-top. Heart shirt," she listed flatly. "I'm Mermista. Glimmer's friend, you know, from student council."

Glimmer had run for president senior year, and actually won. Bow could hardly believe it when she told him. His best friend, who used to only care about video games and road trips, suddenly politicking her way into college credits or whatever.

He had never thought she cared about things like that.

"I know you, actually. Nice to officially meet you," Bow said, offering his hand. She glanced at it, one eyebrow arched in disinterest, and left him hanging.

He let it drop, awkwardly. "Uh… so where is she?"

"With the others. Come on." Mermista gestured him deeper into the huge house. Whose place was this, anyway? Probably one of Glimmer's new student council friends.

Bow felt a flicker of pride there. She had made new friends all on her own, something she struggled with, growing up with no siblings and richer than anyone she knew. Mixed in with that pride, though, was a pinch of jealousy he quickly stomped down.

"She's soooo gone, by the way," Mermista drawled, looking not much better herself.

They entered a sort of lounge area, adjacent to the living room, where the music was louder.

“Found him!”

A blur of blonde hair rushed past Mermista, and suddenly Bow’s hands were clutched in another pair.

“Hi! I’m Perfuma. Finally nice to meet you! I’ve heard loads about you!”

He knew her, too, as Scorpia’s girlfriend, though this was the first time Bow had met her in person. What a small world. Their circle really had gone full circle.

Before Bow could mention it, Perfuma dragged him to their table, rambling. “It’s a miracle you’re in town already. Everyone else is still in uni, and Glimmer made us promise not to call her mom. Besides, you’re her emergency contact!”

The way she said it, it dawned on Bow that she was sorry for bothering him, for asking him to come pick up *their* friend.

“No, I don’t mind,” Bow reassured, smiling tight. “Of course I’m happy to pick her up. She’s my best friend.” He glanced around, already itching to leave. “Where is she?”

He was usually the friendly, sociable guy, but after the disaster trip home, the missed dinner, and now standing stone-cold sober and feeling completely out of place in a house of drunk people, Bow wanted nothing more than to crawl into his bed and end the night.

But not without what he came here for in the first place.

“Hey, Glimmer!” Mermista shouted at the top of her lungs, somehow still sounding deadpan. The call was loud enough to make his ears ring. “Your ride’s here!”

Mermista nonchalantly jerked her chin toward the living room.

He turned. Through the wide archway, the party was a blur of motion and noise. And then he heard her. Her laugh, loud and

boisterous, cutting over everything else. Of course he'd know it anywhere.

Glimmer came into view at the same time everyone else seemed to fade. She was spinning and laughing, carefree as she danced, twirled and swayed into the arms of someone else.

A pang hit Bow square in the chest before he made out her partner. Scorpia.

Without the older woman's support, Glimmer was obviously tripping over her feet, close to falling. Bow pushed through the crowd of drunken bodies to reach her, who was bobbing her head to the beat, eyes closed.

"Hey!" Bow called out. Only Scorpia turned, her face lighting up.

"Bow, buddy! You're here! Adora too?"

Bow nodded. "Yeah! With Catra!"

Scorpia grinned, wide. "Awesome! Can't wait to catch up! But I need a refill, and this one—" she gestured helplessly at Glimmer, "—will not stop dancing! I can't leave her alone, look at her!"

Bow laughed. "I've got her!" he shouted back, prying Glimmer from Scorpia and catching her full weight against him.

Scorpia gave him a grateful thumbs up and a million thank yous before disappearing into the crowd.

"Scropia! Nooo, don't gooo!" Glimmer cried after her, reaching out. Realizing she was now leaning against someone new, she tipped her head back, peering at Bow upside down.

"Who are yo—oh… HEYYY!"

Bow's grin widened instantly, his chest suddenly full and fuzzy, warm as though he'd downed a few drinks himself. Her wide eyes,

glassy but bright with recognition, were fixed on him like they were the only two people in the room.

She turned to face him properly, arms immediately wrapping around his neck, giggling.

Bow's arm circled her waist, holding her upright. In this proximity, he saw how flushed her face was, her lips pink and glossy from drinking. Her dyed-pink hair caught the light, shimmering.

Her hands absentmindedly threaded through his hair, a movement that shot straight through his spine.

"Hey, yourself," Bow said, lips close to her ear for no other reason than to avoid shouting, of course.

Glimmer pressed her palms against his cheeks. "Are youu *real*?"

Bow laughed. "Yep, Bow in the flesh."

Glimmer squealed, launching into him with a crushing hug. She whirled toward the crowd. "GUYSS—BOW IS HOMEEE!" she yelled, absolutely loud.

The drunken crowd cheered, pumping red cups in the air and sloshing drinks all over the place, though Bow was sure he didn't recognize even a tenth of those faces.

He and Glimmer clung to each other, in full giggles now, giddy to finally be reunited. Bow lifted her slightly, spinning her once, feeling like the world had righted itself with her in his arms.

Her warmth pressed in close, her unmistakably sweet perfume, vanilla shampoo when he buried his face in her hair. Every detail a punch of familiarity he hadn't realized he'd ached for.

God, how he'd missed her.

The music grew louder, even more feral in its celebration. And that was his cue. Bow all but carried Glimmer out of there before

they sustained ear damage.

He guided them back to the lounge, where he eased her onto the couch beside her friends.

“Dang, she really let loose,” Scorpia said from the other end, watching Glimmer’s head loll before coming to rest against Mermista’s shoulder.

“Aw, she deserves it,” Perfuma cooed, curling into Scorpia’s side. “She worked so hard to get into your college, you know.”

Right. That’s what she’d been burning herself out over all year, so busy with that single-minded goal that he rarely saw her over the breaks. And so was he, if he were being honest, what with adjusting to the newness of freshman year and his academic demands piling up. And yet, somehow, they still managed to call each other daily.

When she’d finally held up her acceptance letter on camera, he’d teared up from relief. That first year without her had been brutal, like walking around missing a limb. And now… now she was here.

“Yeah,” Bow murmured, tucking a stray lock of hair from her face. “But I think she’s had enough celebration for tonight,” he chuckled softly.

He grabbed a water bottle off the table, twisted it open, and gently pulled her back against his chest. “Hey, Glimmer. You need to drink this before we head out.”

She made a noise of protest, but her fingers closed around the bottle with his help. She chugged it in one go.

The sudden hush from her friends made him glance up. They were all watching, the most obvious being Perfuma, who was biting back a giggle and hiding in Scorpia’s shoulder.

“...What?”

“Nothing,” Perfuma said too quickly, waving him off.

He cleared his throat, feeling slightly embarrassed now. “Okay, well. I should get her home.”

Mermista plucked Glimmer’s bag off the couch, holding it out between two fingers. “Her car keys should be in there… somewhere. And she’s parked out front. Know her car?”

“Of course. Thanks.” He slung it over his shoulder. “I’ll have her text you when she gets in. If she ever sobers up.”

Perfuma gave him a look like she wanted to say more, but just smiled instead. “Good night, Bow. We’ll see you again soon, no doubt!”

Bow smiled back, waving to the group goodbye.

He stood, slipping an arm around Glimmer and lifting her into his arms. She didn’t even seem to register that she was now being carried, simply mumbling something against his chest.

“Yeah, you’re right,” he said, even though he hadn’t really understood her. “Let’s get out of here.”

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Bow slid into the driver’s seat, tossed Glimmer’s handbag into the back, and checked her again. The air outside and the water she’d downed had sobered her a little, but not by much.

Glimmer leaned against the window, watching the crowd outside the house through glazed eyes. This was deja vu because Bow swore they were in this exact same scene almost a year ago, only then it had been her driving him. That was the night she confesse —Well, it was up for debate if that really happened or not.

Bow shook off the thought. Now wasn’t the time. He leaned over, tugged her seatbelt, ignoring her half-coherent protest of doing it

herself, and clicked it into place.

He then slotted the keys into the ignition and turned it. The dash lit up, but the engine sputtered like it was choking for a good half-minute before dying.

Bow frowned, tried again but again, it emitted nothing but a pathetic whine. He glanced at the gauge and groaned. Empty.

"Unbelievable," he muttered under his breath, equal parts exasperated and endeared because of course. She changed so much and yet not at all, only Glimmer could be such an amusing contradiction of herself.

From the passenger side, Glimmer peeked through half-lidded eyes. "...Wah?"

Bow sighed, pocketing his phone and keys, making sure to crack her window just enough for air to slip through. The pulse of the party music spilled back in almost instantly.

"I'll be back. I'll go see if we can borrow someone's car," Bow said, halfway to opening the door before he felt a persistent tug on his arm.

Glimmer was upright now, eyes glazed but fixed on him. "What, whyy?"

"Because, Glimmer, your tank's dry," Bow looked at her pointedly, and if she were sober, she would get an earful from him just about now. "I don't know why you always let it get this low, but yeah. This thing's not moving."

She scoffed, arms crossing and tone mocking his as she defended her life choices. "Well, *because*, *Boww,* the gauge lies. There's *always* more gas left."

"Mhmm. Sure. Your theory worked out great tonight."

Glimmer pursed her lips, annoyed, and then reached out and pinched his cheeks between her fingers.

"Ow—quit it!" He protested, laughing.

Glimmer released him with a huff, unclicked her seatbelt, and shoved her door open. "Let's just walk then!" she said, stubbornly.

Bow scoffed, half-amused. "Yeah, says the girl who can't even stand, let alone walk."

"I *can* walk!" she shot back, shoving the handle harder. She stumbled the instant her heels hit the pavement, nearly toppling over before she caught herself in time. "Seeee? Nailed it," she declared proudly, clinging to the door like a lifeline. "Now, let's goo–"

Bow was at her side in a blink, steadying her as she wobbled forward. "Uh-huh. If walking means face-planting into the pavement."

"You're very mean," Glimmer glared, pouting.

"And you're very cute," Bow grinned cheekily, tapping her cheek with one finger. She batted it away, but her blush was telling.

"...simp," she muttered, making sure the "p" popped.

Bow flushed at the playful callout, turning his glare on her. Thankfully, the stoplight at the corner washed him red, hiding the worst of it.

Glimmer's smug little smirk though told him she knew she'd won this round.

Oh, two could play at that game. Without a word, Bow crouched, slid his arms around her knees, and hoisted her onto a piggyback.

"Hey—!" She squeaked, wrapping her arms tight around his shoulders. "I can *walk!*"

“Sure you can,” Bow said dryly, locking her car with a click and adjusting her weight. “Let’s get you home, you big baby.”

Despite her initial protests, she quickly settled pretty comfortably on his back, chin resting on his shoulder and her hair brushing his jaw.

They walked in silence, the party music fading behind them until it was just his shoes on the pavement, the faint rustle of leaves in the wind, and Glimmer softly humming the theme song of her favourite cartoon.

Her house was only a couple blocks away, close enough. Though, with her weight against his back, Bow couldn’t help wishing it was a little farther.

“Sooo,” Glimmer slurred at last, voice muffled against his shoulder. “Mermista was sayinggg some nonsense earlier… Wanna hear it?”

Bow spared her a glance. “Sure.”

“She goesss,” she said, drawing out her words, mimicking her friend’s tone. “‘If you call a guy friend to pick you up at a party, and he calls you a cab? He doesn’t like you that way.’”

Bow huffed a laugh.

“But—” she dragged it out dramatically, “if he drives you home… then either he’s a really good friend… or he likes you.”

He chuckled, shaking his head. “That’s some very flawed logic.”

“Pfft. What, you expect groundbreaking wisdom from a bunch of drunks?” she shot back, and then, after a beat: “Sooo… which is it?”

“Which is what?”

She groaned, smacked his shoulder lightly. “Were you even listening! You were gonna drive me home, right? Soooo, are you…

a really good friend, or you like me?”

Bow almost tripped, caught completely off guard because she’d said it so matter-of-factly he wasn’t even sure he’d heard her right.

He tightened his hold on her. After a beat, he said, “Well… I technically didn’t drive you home.”

“Oh… right.” Glimmer shrugged, resting her head on his shoulder, and seemingly ran out of interest in his answer. “Doesn’t count then, nevermindd.”

“I’m carrying you home instead,” Bow insisted, voice much softer now. He could’ve just let it go, Glimmer gave him as good an exit as any, but he couldn’t help himself. “What did Mermista say about that?”

“Hmm, she didn’t say,” Glimmer mumbled, her finger tracing lazy patterns on his arm. “But you could… probably figure it out.”

“If he’s carrying you home,” Bow hummed, as if he was in thought. His heart was thundering in his chest as he said his next words. “...well, then he’s probably in love with you.”

The silence stretched before Glimmer’s giggling broke it. “Hmmmm. Yeppp. Maybe.”

There was a beat again, and all the while Bow’s heart ticked in his chest like a bomb.

“Are you?” she asked, her finger paused tracing against his arm.

His breath caught, loud and heavy against his ears. “...You could probably figure it out.”

Her laugh vibrated against his shoulder and tickled the hairs on his neck.

"Knewwww it. *Sheesh,* what does a girl have to do to get a straight answer from this guyy? Leaving the audience in suspense, like what, it's some big reveal? Get over yourself!"

Bow opened and closed his mouth, looking like a goldfish as he struggled to defend himself from her teasing.

"I just—just don't want to do it while you're drunk and you wouldn't remember!"

"Ohhh, you mean like how I did it?" she fired back instantly.

"Uh, yeah! Feeling like my head was being turned inside out doesn't make it any easier to process my best friend confessing to me."

Her gasp was sharp and delighted. "OHHH. So you *do* remember."

Oh, they were in charged territory now. A whole year they'd hovered at the edge of this line—the meaningful pauses in conversations, the teasing little comments, the coy looks. It had driven him insane, never knowing if it was actually something or just him imagining things!

But if this exchange proved anything, it was that *that night* did happen. It wasn't a fever dream, not some drunken hallucination.

"Of course, I remembered!"

"Well, it sure didn't seem like it," Glimmer shot back, words slurring but tone sharp. "The way you acted like nothing happened."

Bow faltered, drew a deep, patient breath. Then the dam broke.

"Oh Glimmer, now you've got it twisted." His pace had quickened, each step with a bit more weight than the last as the memory of those first few weeks resurfaced. "It was *you* who acted like nothing happened. I mean, *you disappeared* for a month! You didn't say goodbye, no message, nothing. Then you turn up out of

the blue, chatting like you hadn't just ghosted me, and *never* brought it up again, not *once*. I was drunk—you gaslighted me into thinking I imagined the whole thing!"

She went quiet while he ranted, deservedly so. She knew what she did, Bow thought. The only sound was the scuff of his shoes and his hard breathing.

Finally, she spoke quieter, sounding more sober. "Well… that was the plan," she admitted, drawing a breath. "You know, the classic 'pretend embarrassing things never happened and hope everyone just forgets'…. Sorryyy."

Bow sighed, leaning his head back and bumping it gently against hers in acknowledgement. He was exasperated but he understood; he couldn't exactly blame her, not when he'd been with someone else at the time.

Their thoughts seemed to follow the same track, because Glimmer spoke again, tentative.

"Was that the reason you broke up with Sea Hawk?" There was genuine guilt there.

Bow sighed, squeezing her thighs where his hands rested. "No. I mean, yeah, it was part of it. Mostly, I just figured out what I really wanted."

He glanced at her and caught her staring at him. Both of them looked away too quickly.

"Hmmm," Glimmer hugged his shoulders tighter. "Glad I helped."

They reached her house, and Bow carried her up to the porch, lowering her carefully onto the step and then plopping right next to her. She leaned against his shoulder, and Bow let his head rest on hers.

They rested there for a bit, letting him catch his breath.

“I missed you,” she murmured, yawning a bit as she took his hand in both hers and played idly with his fingers. “I’m glad you're back.”

“I missed you, too,” Bow said, bouncing his palm with hers. “Just… wish we could’ve seen each other first at dads’ dinner instead of at the party. I’d like to reunite with my sober best friend first, please and thank you.

Glimmer laughed softly. “I think the night went great as is!”

Bow nudged her with his elbow, looking at her seriously and with meaning. “Hey. We really need to stop having *this* conversation while one of us is hammered.”

Glimmer giggled, drawing her knees up to her chest and peering at him over them, her messy hair and the porch light creating a halo around her head.

“Why? It’s the only time we get any progress.”

He snorted. “We’re hopeless then.”

He brushed a stray lock of hair from her face, and for a moment, they just looked at each other, savoring their reunion.

His gaze slipped to her lips, lingered there.

“You know… you tried to kiss me that night,” Glimmer said suddenly, smirking, coy. “You remember that?”

Bow’s whole face flushed, looking away and covering his mouth. “I was drunk.”

“You don’t have an excuse now, Mr. Sober,” she teased. “But I do.”

He turned to her, confused—then froze, eyes widening, as she leaned in, lips hovering over his, before pressing a kiss chastely just on the corner of his lips.

When she pulled away, Bow could barely hear anything over the pounding in his chest.

"Payback for last timeee," Glimmer said, sing-song.

His eyes were glued to her lips still, and it was as if gravity was pulling him down towards it. All he had to do was lean down.

Bow cleared his throat and forced himself to stand. "Alright. I think it's time you go in and rest."

He helped her up, a hand on her back, and unlocked her door with his spare key. He handed her handbag and they stood there in the doorway, both flushed and smiling. She leaned against the frame, and Bow fought every impulse in him not to lean closer.

"'Night, Glimmer."

Glimmer traced her finger on the corner of his lips. "Give me a proper one tomorrow?"

Bow caught her finger and laid a small peck on the tip. "That's if you remember any of this."

Glimmer smirked. "I trust you'll catch me up. Nightie night!"

When the door closed, Bow leaned on it, catching his breath. Drunk Glimmer was not for the faint of heart.

He shook his head, climbing down the porch, muttering under his breath. But the grin on his face was as wide as the break of dawn.

Chapter 3: The next day

Glimmer kicked the door to the house shut, pulling her hoodie over her eyes to block the afternoon sun. She wrapped her arms around herself as she stomped across the gardens and into the car parked out front.

She groaned as soon as she saw his face, looking all cheerful and knowing. That was unacceptable, not when her head felt like it was splitting in half.

“Shut up,” she croaked, slumping into her seat.

“Good morning to you too,” Bow greeted, way too chipper as he turned in his seat to face her.

Glimmer reached for the electrolyte drink on the console. “This mine?” He waved it off and Glimmer took a generous gulp, feeling like a plant getting its first rainshower after a drought.

He always knew what to do when she was hungover.

“I brought coffee too.” Bow reached into the back seat, holding out a tray with two cups. “Black. No sugar. Just how you *pretend* you like it,” he teased, earning him an unamused glare from her bloodshot eyes. “Orrr, I also have this latte. Three pumps of cream and *so much* sugar—”

She snatched the latter with a gruff 'thanks’ and took a sip. Her soul sang as the caffeine and sugar hit.

Bow chuckled as he sipped from the unchosen black coffee. He plopped a warm paper bag on her lap. “And a bagel. For your grumpies.”

“Yesss,” Glimmer whispered reverently, taking a deep whiff. She slipped off her shoes, tucked her legs under her, and leaned back. “You’re the best,” she mumbled around a bite, humming happily.

"I try," Bow said, stealing a bite when she wordlessly offered it. "So… how's the head?"

"Exploding," Glimmer groaned. "I can't believe I have to socialize in this state."

"We can always cancel," he shrugged, wondering if it would be rude to bail on Adora's homecoming dinner party at the last minute. "Adora will understand."

"No, I want to be a good friend," Glimmer sighed, taking another bite of her bagel. "Let's go before I change my mind."

"Okay, but before that…" he paused. "Do you remember last night?"

Glimmer froze halfway through a bite, mouth open, and stayed like that as she sat upright, stiffly. The pounding in her chest not helping at all with the pounding in her head.

"Of course," she admitted, barely audible through the hand covering her mouth. Dang, she couldn't even look at him!

"And?" Bow pressed gently. "Hey. Look at me?"

Glimmer groaned, begrudgingly turning, and nearly choked when she came face-to-face with him, inches away and leaning over the console. "Bow! Are you seriously trying to give me a heart attack?" she hissed, hand on her chest dramatically.

Bow laughed, unbothered. "Well, don't you think we should talk about it?"

Her entire face was on fire and she was sure her ears were completely red. She wished she had the confidence of someone who didn't feel like her head was slowly disintegrating to wipe the teasing smirk off his face.

She placed a hand on his chest, gently pushing him back to give her some space because she was breathless and *hot*! Damn, was

the AC even on?

"Ye-yes," she managed, forcing her eyes to stay on his. "Yes, of course, we *will* talk about it. Just not while my head's ticking like a bomb... I promise."

Bow studied her, a knowing look on his face, before he finally took mercy and sat back with a satisfied grin. "Okay. We'll shelve it for later."

Glimmer blew a deep breath, finally feeling her chest expand now that he wasn't in her face. "Yep. Later."

He turned on the engine, the car coming alive. "You owe me," he flashed her a smug grin, which in her shitty state, was annoying.

"I seem to recall *you* owe *me*," she muttered under her breath, sulkily.

"What was that?" Bow's teasing tone came back, and Glimmer sputtered, not expecting to be heard. "Oh right, I *do* owe you… what was it you said? A proper kiss?"

Her heart stopped, right there and then. She was dead. It felt like hell itself appeared under her feet to swallow her whole. She doubled over, hiding her melting face behind her hands, and groaned.

"Bowwww! You are killing *me!"*

He answered with a full-bellied laugh, and Glimmer remained hidden like that as the car finally moved.

"Don't worry," he said smugly. "I'm saving that for later, too."

"Uuuughhhh!!!"

&

“Glimmer you’ve gone absolutely insane!”

“The dumb look on their faces! HA!”

They bounded across the front yard and into the streets, high-tailing it into Bow’s car. They fell onto the seats, breathless from running, adrenaline, and laughter.

“That definitely cracked the top ten funniest things you’ve ever done,” Bow said, shaking his head, grinning.

Something in their body language must’ve shifted with last night’s drunken revelations, because from the moment they arrived at Adora's dinner party, everyone—their friends and family in attendance—kept giving them these teasing looks and offhand comments.

It didn’t help that Bow just would not let go of her hand, so they’d clung to each other all night. He was beaming, all grins and laughter, while she had grumpily nursed a headache, leaning on him to shield her from having to socialize.

Yeah, in hindsight, they probably *looked* friendlier than usual. Honestly, they probably had it coming.

But between Bow’s parents and Castapella not-so-subtly fishing for info, and Glimmer’s dad deflecting like she was a kindergartener too innocent for love, her migraine was reaching its limit. Coupled with Bow’s knowing looks and touches that were killing her, dangling that overdue conversation over her head, she’d had just about enough.

So when Angella, with the faintest hint of a smirk, remarked, “Hmm…you two seem…cozy tonight,” something inside her snapped.

Too hungover to properly think her next actions through, she slammed her fist on the table, leaned across, grabbed Bow by the collar, and kissed him. In front of everyone’s salad.

“There. We just started dating,” Glimmer declared stubbornly, but face completely scarlet red at the realization of what she’d done. Bow was frozen, gaping at her.

“Let’s go consummate this union, Bow,” she said, all but stomping out of the dining area, no longer feeling her face, but if they were so set on embarrassing her, well, she could embarrass them even more.

She heard Bow stumble after her, bumping into furniture and muttering endless ‘sorries’ as they left the stunned table behind. Glimmer grabbed him by the arm and quickened their pace until they were practically running and laughing out the door.

“You’ve shocked them into their next life,” Bow laughed breathlessly. “Boy, am I glad I’m not in that room anymore.”

She remembered how the clatter of utensils had faded into awkward silence. Their friends’ hands over their mouths, and the parents gaped, dumbfounded at her absolute *gall*.

“Your dad’s going to murder me,” he added, arm on his forehead as the scene replayed in his head.

“Shush, Mom loves you. Dad doesn’t stand a chance—”

“GLIMMER!” Micah’s booming voice came from the doorway, with a flustered George behind him, calling out his son’s name, ”Bow!”

“OH SHIT. DRIVE, DRIVEEEEE!” Glimmer slapped Bow’s arm frantically. With shaking hands, he started the car. In the side mirror, they watched their dads paced helplessly in the yard, ranting to each other.

Well, they might as well start bonding now.

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“To celebrate our announcement…” Glimmer pulled out a bottle of wine, waving it at him. “I was able to snag this. ”

“Oooh wine, fancy,” Bow played along. “But, see, I thought you had a hangover.”

“Uh huh. Some would say the best cure to a hangover is a teensy dose of alcohol,” she said smugly.

Bow snorted, rolling his eyes playful.

“But before we touch that…” Glimmer suddenly sat primly on the edge of her seat, looking at him earnestly. “I believe I owe you a stone-cold sober conversation.”

“I’m ready when you are,” Bow said, mirroring her posture, a tender grin on his lips.

After the chaos of dinner, she’d built up the courage to talk to him seriously as they drove around town, and by the time Bow finally stopped the car at the park, she almost felt confident.

But now, with him looking at her so intently, expectantly, she felt her nerve slipping. The memory of his lips on hers from earlier sent her heart racing.

She took a deep inhale, then blew it out. That wine was starting to look a little too good now.

“...This feels way too serious now, doesn’t it?” she cracked a nervous grin.

“Yeah, might as well get a witness and take an oath on a bible,” he said in jest to lift up some of the tension in the air.

“Just one sip?” she asked sheepishly, already cranking the bottle open. “For courage. That still counts as sober, right?”

Bow reached out for her hand, running his thumb on the back of it.

“Cheers.” She tilted the glass, taking a cautious sip and immediately making a face.

“Good?” Bow asked, laughing.

“Not at all,” she grimaced.

“Can I taste?”

Glimmer looked at him. The question was innocent enough, but the look on Bow’s face was meaningful. She had a feeling…

“Sure.”

Instead of the wine, Bow leaned in slowly, giving her enough time to pull away—but why would she?—and kissed her.

Her eyes immediately fluttered closed as she leaned in. The taste of alcohol, faintly bitter yet sweet, mingled with him. He tasted better than how she imagined a year ago, or even last night, when they were stuck in a car like now—only this time, it was onlyhim that intoxicated her.

They broke apart, breaths washing over their lips as they stared at each other, hearts racing even as the world around them slowed down. At the same time, wide but shy smiles curved at their lips.

“Hmm, I don’t know. I think that wine tastes pretty great,” Bow murmured, a smirk in his voice. “How’s that for a proper kiss?”

Glimmer’s fingers curled in his shirt collar. “Hmm, I don’t know. Let me check again.”

Without hesitation now, she tugged him closer, pulling him down into a deeper kiss until he was pressed against her, not minding the sound of the wine bottle as it toppled to the floor.

It had already done its job after all.

End Notes

If you've found your way here, your comments are treasured and appreciated! I keep them in my shrine and light candles for them every day /j.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!